

CULTURE AND SOCIETY

Academic integrity principles

Sciences Po's educational project encourages students to develop **independent and critical thinking, intellectual honesty and respect for copyright and image rights** in the use of sources.

To help you meet these requirements and consolidate your learning, we invite you to refer to the following documents and resources:

[Academic rules and regulation \(article 12\);](#)

[Academic integrity charter;](#)

[Mandatory academic integrity online training](#) on Moodle;

[Methodological resources](#) on the student website.

We remind you that any fraud or proven attempted fraud will be punished in accordance with the [disciplinary procedures](#) in force at Sciences Po.

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Spring semester

Course description

This course offers a sociological exploration of culture, focusing on how cultural phenomena shape, and are shaped by political, social, and economic structures in society. Designed as a research methodology workshop, it provides students theoretical tools and empirical techniques to study cultural practices, their role in the construction of identity, power, values, and their political implications. The first four sessions will focus on theoretical approaches in cultural sociology and then the following sessions will focus on empirical sociological analyses, allowing students to engage with concrete research examples and methodological applications.

Central to the course is addressing themes such as gender, race, social inequality, religion, social movements, social change, and the influence of technology and artificial intelligence through various cultural forms such as art, fashion, dance, performance, protest, language. Students will also explore how contemporary issues, such as digital media and AI, gender and race influence cultural production and politics, reshaping social movements, and how culture both reinforces and challenges social structures.

Type of course

Research methodology workshop

Pedagogical objectives

- Understand core sociological concepts regarding culture's role in society.
- Analyze the interplay between culture and social, political, and economic structures.
- Critically assess intersections of cultural phenomena with issues like gender, race, religion, power, social inequality, and technology.
- Explore transnational cultural exchanges and production and its role in politics and social change.

The course combines short lectures on theoretical and methodological concepts, group discussions and debates on assigned readings, including student-led oral presentations of selected texts. It also includes fieldwork assignments, such as micro-ethnographies, digital ethnography, interviews, discourse and visual analysis, alongside a group research project that culminates in a final research paper. These assignments are designed to strengthen methodological, theoretical, academic writing skills and support students in developing sociological inquiry.

Course grade system

The course will be validated based on the following grades:

- Oral presentation 25%
- Fieldwork assignments 15%
- Class participation 10%
- Research paper 50%

Oral presentation

Each week, one or two students will present in class a selected text related session's theme. Students will choose their presentation week and text during the first session. Presentations should be supported by visual PowerPoint and must not exceed 15-20 minutes. This exercise aims to strengthen students' ability to synthesize academic literature and engage the class in critical discussion. Presentations should be sent by mail to the teacher 24 hours before class.

Fieldwork assignments

Students will complete short fieldwork exercises designed to introduce key qualitative research methods in sociology. These assignments include conducting micro-ethnographies in everyday cultural spaces, performing digital ethnography on online platforms, keeping a field diary, and carrying out brief discourse or visual analyses of selected materials. Each task requires students to

collect empirical data, apply the methodological tools discussed in class, and produce a short analytical note connecting their observations to relevant sociological concepts within their research papers.

Class participation

Students are expected to come prepared, complete the required readings, and contribute to discussions, debates, and workshop activities. Participation also includes engaging with peers during presentations, offering constructive feedback, and collaborating during group exercises.

Research papers

Throughout the semester, students will work on an individual research paper that applies the methodological tools and theoretical perspectives covered in the course to a cultural phenomenon of their choice. The paper should be based on original empirical material and demonstrate a clear sociological research question, methodological approach, and analytical argument. A proposal and preliminary bibliography will be submitted in week 3, with the final paper due at the end of the course.

Deadlines for the research paper:

- Week 3: A paper proposal of 400-500 words outlining your subject and proving its feasibility. It will notably include the problematic, envisaged methodology, a preliminary hypothesis, and a short bibliography.
- Week 8: A detailed outline consisting of a written-out introduction and complete bibliography. You will also be presenting an outline of your paper – the different sections and a sketch of their content. If you have already written out portions of the paper beyond the above required, this can also be included. The main objective of this exercise is to serve as a checkpoint in the process of writing the paper and for you to obtain feedback.
- Week 12: The research paper is linked to one or more of the themes touched upon during the course. It will be presented in the form of a mini dissertation (research paper) between 3000–4000 words in length (including references). The paper will include original research conducted by you and must reference both primary and secondary sources in addition to your own analysis. It must include a cover page, an abstract, a table of contents, a list of references. With regards to formatting, the paper needs to be presented with font size 12, 1.5 spacing and normal margins. Please use Harvard style of referencing: <https://www.imperial.ac.uk/admin-services/library/learning-support/reference-management/harvard-style/> or <https://university.open.ac.uk/library/referencing-and-plagiarism/quick-guide-to-harvard-referencing-cite-them-right>.

DETAILED OUTLINE

Session 1: Introduction: Understanding culture.

Reading:

Swidler, Ann. "Culture in Action: Symbols and Strategies." *American Sociological Review* 51, no. 2 (April 1986): 273. <https://doi.org/10.2307/2095521>.

Supplementary reading:

Geertz, Clifford. *The Interpretation of Cultures*. New York: Basic Books, [1973] 2008. Chapter 1. <https://public.ebookcentral.proquest.com/choice/publicfullrecord.aspx?p=4785871>.

Session 2: Culture in society: cooperations and inequalities.

Readings:

Becker, Howard Saul. *Art Worlds*. Berkeley (Calif.): University of California press, 2008. Introduction and Chapter 1.

Bourdieu, Pierre. *The Rules of Art: Genesis and Structure of the Literary Field*. Nachdr. Meridian Crossing Aesthetics. Stanford, Calif: Stanford Univ. Press, 2006. pp. 1-34 (Prologue).

Session 3: Cultural sociology.

Readings:

Heinich, Nathalie. "What Does 'Sociology of Culture' Mean? Notes on a Few Trans-Cultural Misunderstandings." *Cultural Sociology* 4, no. 2 (July 2010): 257-65. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1749975510368475>.

Alexander, Jeffrey C. *The Meanings of Social Life: A Cultural Sociology*. Oxford ; New York: Oxford University Press, 2003. Chapter 1 and 6.

Session 4: Culture in globalized society.

Reading:

Bauman, Zygmunt. *Culture in a Liquid Modern World*. Cambridge, Massachusetts: Polity Press, 2011. Chapter 1 and 3.

Session 5: Culture, public space and democracy.

Readings:

Santino, Jack. "The Carnavalesque and the Rituaesque." *The Journal of American Folklore* 124, no. 491 (2011): 61. <https://doi.org/10.5406/jamerfolk.124.491.0061>

Beck, Scott R. "'Walking the Talk': Transposition of Religious Culture in OWS." *American Journal of Cultural Sociology* 12, no. 2 (June 2024): 239-70. <https://doi.org/10.1057/s41290-023-00191-8>.

Session 6: Culture and capital.

Readings:

Groys, Boris. "Art and Money." *E-Flux*, no. Journal #24 (April 2011). <https://www.e-flux.com/journal/24/67836/art-and-money/>.

Menger, Pierre-Michel. "Artistic Labor Markets and Careers." *Annual Review of Sociology* 25, no. 1 (August 1999): 541-74. <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev.soc.25.1.541>.

Session 7: Culture and the body.

Readings:

Lepecki, André. "Choreopolice and Choreopolitics: Or, the Task of the Dancer." *TDR/The Drama Review* 57, no. 4 (December 2013): 13-27. https://doi.org/10.1162/DRAM_a_00300.

Mehlman Petrzela, N. (2020). From Performance to Participation: The Origins of the Fit Nation. *Transatlantica*, 2. <https://doi.org/10.4000/transatlantica.16318>

Session 8: Culture and gender.

Readings:

O'Neill, Rachel. "By, for, with Women? On the Politics and Potentialities of Wellness Entrepreneurship." *The Sociological Review* 72, no. 1 (January 2024): 3-20. <https://doi.org/10.1177/00380261221142461>.

Kuric Kardelis, Stribor. "The Body of a Performer as a Form of Capital: Age, Gender and Aesthetics in Theatre Work." *Cultural Sociology* 17, no. 2 (June 2023): 159-78. <https://doi.org/10.1177/17499755211070142>.

Session 9: Culture and race.

Readings:

hooks, bell. *Black Looks: Race and Representation*. New York: Routledge, 2015. Chapter 9: Is Paris Burning?

Yang, Mina. "East Meets West in the Concert Hall: Asians and Classical Music in the Century of Imperialism, Post-Colonialism, and Multiculturalism." *Asian Music* 38, no. 1 (March 2007): 1-30. <https://doi.org/10.1353/amu.2007.0025>.

To watch: Paris Is Burning (1990), documentary film by Jennie Livingston, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=nl7EhpY2yaA>

Session 10: Culture and fashion.

Readings:

Simmel, Georg. "Fashion." *American Journal of Sociology* 62, no. 6 (May 1957): 541-58. <https://doi.org/10.1086/222102>.

Arús, María A. Cabrera. "Thinking Politics and Fashion in 1960s Cuba: How Not to Judge a Book by Its Cover." *Theory and Society* 46, no. 5 (2017): 411–28.

Session 11: Cultures of AI.

Reading:

Bandinelli, Carolina, and Alessandro Gandini. "Dating Apps: The Uncertainty of Marketised Love." *Cultural Sociology* 16, no. 3 (September 2022): 423–41. <https://doi.org/10.1177/17499755211051559>.

To watch:

The Museum of Modern Art, AI Art: How artists are using and confronting machine learning, March 15, 2023, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=G2XdZIC3AM8>

Session 12: Culture, citizenship, and protest.

Readings:

Campos, Ricardo. "Art and Citizenship: Practices and Discourses of Young Activists in Portugal." *European Journal of Cultural and Political Sociology* 11, no. 2 (April 2, 2024): 190–211. <https://doi.org/10.1080/23254823.2023.2234967>.

Schneider, Nicole. "Black Protest on the Streets." no. 18 (2017). <https://copas.uni-regensburg.de/article/view/276/378>.